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Photography, Artistic feeling, and Artificial Intelligence

When photography first became popular, many people questioned whether it could really be considered art. Some people believed that taking a picture with a camera was just a mechanical process and did not require the creativity that painting or drawing did. Today, we are having a similar conversation about artificial intelligence and digital art. In 2022, Jason M. Allen won first place at the Colorado State Fair with an image he created using Midjounney. This caused a lot of discussion about whether images made with AI should count as fine art. After reading John Andrew's ideas about photography, I found this debate interesting because even though technology has changed, people are still asking many of the same questions about creativity and what makes someone an artist.

In *Studies in Photography*, Andrews explains that photography involves several mechanical steps, including using a camera, focusing the lens, capturing light, and developing the image. However, he believes that knowing how to use a camera is not enough to make someone an artist. A good photograph requires more than just understanding the equipment. The photographer also needs creativity, patience and understanding of what makes an image meaningful. Andrews explains that a true artist must learn to "wait and watch." I understand this as taking time to observe the surroundings instead of rushing to take a picture. An artist needs to notice details, lighting and the right movement to capture something special (Andrews, 1892, p. 5-10)

Andrews also explains that artistic feeling is what separates an ordinary photograph from an ordinary photograph from an artistic one. On page 8, he states, “After all, it is a question of artistic feeling.” I understand this as meaning that art is not only about what a person creates but also about how they see things and what they want to express. Someone might know exactly how to use a camera, but that does not necessarily mean their pictures will have meaning or creativity behind them. Andrews also explains that photography does not have to replace other forms of art. Instead, it can help artists like painters and illustrators by giving them something to use as a reference when studying lighting, details, and perspective. This shows that different types of art can work together without taking away what makes each one unique (Andrews, 1892, p. 8, 18-28).

Another idea that connects to this discussion comes from Ralph Waldo Emerson, who says that art is “Nature passed through the alembic of man.” An alembic is something used to transform or purify a substance. I think Emerson is comparing this process to how artists take something they see in the real world and turn it into something that reflects their own thoughts and creativity. For example, two people could look at the same exact landscape but create two completely different paintings. This is because everyone has their own way of seeing things and expressing themselves. To me, this shows that art is not just about copying what is already there. It is about taking inspiration from the world and adding your own ideas and imagination to it (Andrews, 1892, p.12).

On the other hand, Philip Gilbert Hamerton has a different opinion about photography. He believes that photography is useful for capturing images of people and places, but he does not think it can truly be considered fine art. His argument is that photography depends too much on a machine and does not give the artist enough room to use their imagination. He believes that fine

art should involve more than just showing what something looks like. It should also include personal creativity and expression. I understand what he is trying to say, but I do not completely agree with him. I think photographers still make creative decisions when choosing the lighting, angles, and composition of a picture. These choices can change how someone views an image and what it means to them (Andrews, 1892, p.12)

When it comes to digital art, I think it has a lot in common with traditional painting because both allow people to express their creativity through images. AI-generated art is a little different because the computer creates images based on the prompts it receives and patterns it has learned. However, I do not think it should automatically be considered less artistic. In Jason M. Allen's case, he used Midjourney to create hundreds of different versions before deciding which images he wanted to use. He also made changes using Photoshop and increased the resolution of his final image. Even though AI helped create the image, Allen still had to make decisions about what he wanted and how he wanted the final artwork to look. I think this shows that he was still involved in the creative process (CBS Colorado, 2022).

Personally, I think Allen winning the competition was fair because digital artwork was allowed, and there were no specific rules against using AI. At the same time, I can understand why some artists were upset about it. People who spent hours creating their artwork by hand may have felt that using AI gave Allen an unfair advantage. I think having a separate category for AI-generated artwork would have been a good solution. That way, artists using traditional methods and artists using AI could have both been recognized by their work.

Overall, I believe AI can be another tool that people use to create art, but I also think the person using it needs to bring their own creativity and ideas into the process. This connects to Andrew's idea of artistic feeling and Emmerson's belief that art comes from taking inspiration

from nature and transforming it through human imagination. At the same time, Hamerton's argument reminds us that just because a machine can create an image does not automatically make it meaningful art. In my opinion, AI should not replace the creativity of human artists. What matters is the thought, effort, decisions, and meaning that go into creating the final piece. Technology will continue to change, but I believe the human side of art will always be important.

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